THE WHITE HOUSE

WASHINGTON

September 16, 1998

Dear Mr. Chairman:

Your letter about U.S. policy towards Taiwan raises important issues. As I did in my letter to you on August 18, I would like to again provide a broad description of our policy toward Taiwan. I will also respond to the specific questions you asked in your July 23 letter.

Taiwan's development of a prosperous economy based on free market principles, its emergence as our seventh largest trading partner, and its adoption of a democratic system that protects fundamental human rights are important achievements that benefit not only Taiwan, but the entire region. The policies of U.S. Administrations over the last three decades toward Taiwan and the People's Republic of China have helped create the atmosphere in which democracy and prosperity in Taiwan have flourished. I am committed fully to assuring that this successful record continues.

Our policy toward Taiwan remains unchanged. I articulated publicly and privately during my trip all of the core elements of that policy. We have a "one China" policy based on the three U.S.-PRC Joint Communiqués. Our strong unofficial relations with Taiwan and our continued support for appropriate defensive arms sales to Taiwan are based on the Taiwan Relations Act. These documents establish the key principles that have guided our policy for nearly two decades, including our firm expectation that any resolution of differences between Taipei and Beijing be exclusively by peaceful means; our arms sales to Taiwan; and our policy of not supporting Taiwan independence, "one China, one Taiwan" or "two Chinas," or Taiwan membership in organizations requiring statehood for membership. We do support, however, Taiwan's membership in international organizations that do not require statehood and will work for appropriate ways for Taiwan's voice to be heard in these structures. We strongly support cross-Strait dialogue, but we do not intend to mediate, prescribe the agenda, nor pressure Taiwan to negotiate.

None of these elements of our policy is new. Our adherence to the Taiwan Relations Act and the three Joint Communiqués has been confirmed by each Administration since their enactment and negotiation. Our "one China" policy has been explicit since President Reagan confirmed it in a letter to General Secretary Hu Yaobang in 1982. Our position on Taiwan's independence dates back at least to Henry Kissinger's 1971 visit to China and was put on the record by Deputy Secretary Christopher in 1979 hearings on the Taiwan Relations Act (the ruling party of Taiwan did not then and does not now support independence for Taiwan either). Our position on "one China, one Taiwan" or "two Chinas" dates back to the 1982 Joint Communiqué negotiated by the Reagan Administration. Our expectation of a peaceful settlement is reiterated in each of the Joint Communiqués. And our support for cross-Strait exchanges and dialogue was first asserted by Secretary of State Shultz in 1987.

I made clear in my meeting with President Jiang our insistence that differences between the PRC and Taiwan be resolved peacefully. That was the message I conveyed as well when I ordered deployment of two carrier battle groups to the waters near Taiwan in March 1996. My Administration was pleased to support the Senate Resolution passed in July reaffirming our commitment to the Taiwan Relations Act and calling on the PRC to renounce the use of force against Taiwan.

I will continue to develop our strong unofficial relations with Taiwan and to assure Taiwan is provided the defensive weapons necessary for it to maintain a sufficient self-defense capability. The history of the past quarter century provides strong evidence that Taiwan has fared best when U.S. relations with the PRC are on an even keel and that Taiwan suffers when tensions in U.S.-PRC relations rise. This paradoxical but clear relationship convinces me that improvement in U.S.-PRC relations over the last several years will strengthen Taiwan's interests and security.

I am pleased that Taiwan and the PRC have moved further toward resumption of a formal cross-Strait dialogue since my visit. I believe that this, along with continuing U.S. support within the framework I have outlined above, will best guarantee the future security, prosperity and freedom of Taiwan.

As for your specific questions:

1) I chose to describe all of the elements of our Taiwan policy during my visit, as I stated earlier. We do not have a secret policy toward Taiwan. I believe that clarity about our attitude toward independence, about arms sales, and about peaceful resolution are important so that the people of the PRC, Taiwan, and the United States can understand our policies.

2) U.S. policy is fully consistent with the sections of the Taiwan Relations Act cited in your letter regarding peaceful resolution and Taiwan's membership in international organizations.

3) The Administration has not altered its position about the sovereignty of Taiwan, which was addressed in the 1979 and 1982 U.S.-PRC Joint Communiqués. My statements in the PRC were completely consistent with these long-standing U.S. policies and with the Taiwan Relations Act. The United States will not pressure Taiwan to negotiate with the PRC. However, we have urged both sides to resume cross-Strait discussions.

4) The Administration supports Taiwan's membership in those international organizations where Taiwan has a contribution to make and which do not require statehood for membership. We discuss opportunities for Taiwan's membership or participation frequently with Taiwan's officials to assess the most realistic possibilities and where we can be helpful. We also urge the PRC Government to adopt a more flexible approach to Taiwan's participation in international organizations.

Again, thank you for writing and sharing your concerns on this important issue.

Sincerely,

Bill Clinton

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